Employment Services Participation for Teens	Number	Page
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Revision Date:
October 1, 2025

Background:
State regulations require teen customers ages 16 and 17 years old receiving CalWORKs benefits to be referred to Employment Services (ES) as mandatory participants when the school attendance exemption criteria, as defined in CalWORKs Program Guide (CPG) 10-020.A, are not met.

Note: Chronic truancy and post-secondary education are defined in CPG sections 42-100.B and 10-020.A.

Purpose:
The purpose of this section is to provide guidance regarding ES participation requirements for teen customers who receive CalWORKs assistance.

The purpose of this revision is to incorporate regulation changes that removed the once-in-a-lifetime ES participation exemption limit for 16 and 17 year old teens who are required to attend school, remove references regarding the obsolete Welfare To Work (WTW) 24-Month Time Clock, update references, add clarifying language, and to complete the sunset review.

Policy:
Teen ES Program Requirements
Teen customers ages 16 to 18 years old receiving CalWORKs assistance are exempt from ES participation if attending an educational program in grade 12 or below, or attending a vocational or technical school on a full-time basis as defined by the school/school program.

Teens will be referred to ES if deemed a chronic truant, not meeting the school attendance requirement, or if they have graduated from high school or the equivalent and are not meeting the post-secondary education exemption, including former Cal-Learn teens. These teens are required to participate in ES and are subject to ES program requirements. This includes teens who have completed participation in the Cal-Learn program.

Teens will be evaluated for ES exemptions (see CPG 10-020.A for a list of qualifying exemptions) and, if determined exempt, may participate in ES voluntarily.

Teens who are referred to ES will attend Orientation and Appraisal. The Employment Case Manager (ECM) will also conduct an Assessment to evaluate the teen's individual service needs and develop an ES plan that considers their educational and occupational goals.

Requalifying for ES Student Exemption for Teens 16 and 17 Years Old
Teens aged 16 and 17 years old who lose their ES exemption for not meeting the student criteria, may requalify for the student exemption from ES participation by resuming full-time school attendance in high school, or a vocational or technical school and providing supporting documentation from their school/school program. This exemption does not apply to pregnant or parenting teens in the Cal-Learn program.

Note: Teens referred to ES after being deemed as chronic truants cannot requalify under the student exemption and will participate in ES until completion of secondary school to avoid a school attendance penalty. Only 16 and 17 year old teens who resume and verify full-time school attendance can requalify for the exemption from ES participation.

ES Forms, Notices, and Appointments

All ES forms and notices sent to the teen will also be addressed and sent to their parent/caretaker. Teens are required to sign all applicable ES forms, including the ES plan. Teens will attend all ES appointments. The parent/caretaker is not required to attend the teen's ES appointments but may do so. The parent/caretaker may not attend ES appointments or sign any required ES documents on behalf of the teen.

School Attendance Verifications

Documentation to verify regular school attendance may include monthly attendance records, classroom time sheets, report cards, etc.

Supportive Services

Supportive services may be issued to the extent needed for the teen to attend school and be successful in their activities. The payments will be issued to the teen's parent/caretaker's EBT account.

ES Participation Requirements and Time Clocks

Teens are not subject to the following requirements:

- Minimum hourly ES participation.
- CalWORKs Time on Aid (TOA).

The required number of participation hours for the teen's ES plan may not exceed 20 average hours per week. Any hours assigned beyond 20 average hours per week will be considered voluntary.

The teen's required participation or noncompliance:

- Has no effect on the parent's TOA clock.
- Cannot contribute toward the parent's participation requirements, nor can the parent contribute hours toward the teen's participation requirements.

As a reminder, a parent's ES plan will reflect their child's school attendance requirements and any participation required by the parent to ensure their child's school attendance.

CalFresh Sanctions

Non head of household 16 and 17 year old teens are exempt from CalFresh work registration requirements and are not subject to CalFresh sanctions if they fail to meet ES program requirements. (However, if the head of household teen fails to comply with ES program requirements, they may be subject to a CalFresh sanction which will result in a reduction to the household's CalFresh allotment amount.)

ES Plan Requirements for Teens Not Regularly Attending High School (HS)

The sole purpose of an ES plan for a teen who is not regularly attending high school is to ensure that the teen completes high school or its equivalent. The teen may voluntarily participate in other ES

activities if the activities do not interfere with their school attendance. The teen will sign the ES plan in agreement with their assigned ES activities. Non-participation in voluntary activities is not considered non-compliance.

Teens referred to ES for the sole purpose of completing high school or its equivalent will be identified on the ES plan as participating in, "satisfactory progress in a secondary school or in a course leading to a certificate of general educational development", along with other approved activities that do not interfere with the primary school activity. If a teen is unable to comply with the ES requirement because they have not been enrolled in a secondary school, the ECM will assist them in becoming enrolled and allow good cause until they are enrolled.

Noncompliance with ES for Teens Not Regularly Attending HS

A teen who fails to comply, without good cause, with their required ES plan activity is subject to a school attendance penalty, not an ES sanction. A school attendance penalty will not be applied if the teen meets an ES exception reason.

Restoration of Aid for Teens Not Regularly Attending HS

Once imposed, the school attendance penalty will continue unless:

- Documentation is received that verifies the teen is no longer deemed a chronic truant.
- The teen complies with their ES plan.
- Good cause exists.
- An ES exemption/exception reason is met.
- The teen receives a high school diploma or equivalent.

Conclusion of ES Participation for Teens Not Regularly Attending HS

Verification issued by the school will be provided to demonstrate that the teen has earned a high school diploma or the equivalent. If the teen continues to be eligible for CalWORKs, and mandatory ES participation is required, a new ES plan would be developed.

ES Plan Requirements for Teens Who Completed HS or Equivalent

ES plans for teens who complete HS or equivalent:

- May include any ES activity leading to further education, job preparation, and employment.
- Will indicate all ES activities and hours .
- Will indicate a required number of weekly participation hours agreed upon by the ECM and teen – not to exceed 20 hours per week.
- Will be signed by the teen.

Noncompliance with ES for Teens Who Completed HS or Equivalent

Teens who have completed high school or the equivalent are subject to ES noncompliance and sanction regulations. These teens may cure a sanction by participating in a sanction curing plan and performing the activities they previously failed or refused to perform, or other appropriate activities determined by the ECM.

Procedure:

Processing Guide 10-005.K1 - ES Activities for High School Students.

References:
EAS 42-712, 42-713, 42-719.
ACL No. 15-22, 16-99, 23-30.

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by October 31, 2028.

Approval for Release:

10-27-25

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